impossible for the authorities to prevent it. Even worse, from the viewpoint of Putin's regime, what happens if authorised bots gradually develop dissenting views by themselves, simply by collecting information on what is happening in Russia and spotting patterns in it?

That's the alignment problem, Russian-style. Russia's human engineers can do their best to create AIs that are totally aligned with the regime, but given the ability of AI to learn and change by itself, how can the human engineers ensure that the AI never deviates into illicit territory? It is particularly interesting to note that as George Orwell explained in *Nineteen Eighty-Four*, totalitarian information networks often rely on doublespeak. Russia is an authoritarian state that claims to be a democracy. The Russian invasion of Ukraine has been the largest war in Europe since 1945, yet officially it is defined as a 'special military operation', and referring to it as a 'war' has been criminalised and is punishable by a prison term of up to three years or a fine of up to fifty thousand rubles.[11]

The Russian Constitution makes grandiose promises about how 'everyone shall be guaranteed freedom of thought and speech' (Article 29.1), how 'everyone shall have the right freely to seek, receive, transmit, produce and disseminate information' (29.4) and how 'the freedom of the mass media shall be guaranteed. Censorship shall be prohibited' (29.5). Hardly any Russian citizen is naive enough to take these promises at face value. But computers are bad at understanding doublespeak. A chatbot instructed to adhere to Russian law and values might read that constitution and conclude that freedom of speech is a core Russian value. Then, after spending a few days in Russian cyberspace and monitoring what is happening in the Russian information sphere, the chatbot might start criticising the Putin regime for violating the core Russian value of freedom of speech. Humans too notice such contradictions but avoid pointing them out, due to fear. But what would prevent a chatbot from pointing out damning patterns? And how might Russian engineers explain to a chatbot that though the Russian Constitution guarantees all citizens freedom of speech and forbids censorship, the chatbot shouldn't actually believe the constitution or ever mention the gap between theory and reality? As the Ukrainian guide told me at Chernobyl, people in totalitarian countries grow up with the idea that questions lead to trouble. But if you train an algorithm on the principle that 'questions lead to trouble', how will that algorithm learn and develop?